

Cell Phones



Cellphones are one of the few product categories where dearth of choice is something you will never have to worry about. Manufacturers release handsets in droves. Typically, these spurts of products coincide mostly with festivals, although there are new models available nearly all through the year.

Earlier there were entry-level cellphones for those on shoestring budgets. Then, there were the high-end devices that had all the features that you paid pretty penny for. These two categories were rather segregated. Today, manufacturers realise that variation in choices exist, even in the same price category. For example, one consumer willing to spend Rs 10,000 on a cellphone may be looking for a really good camera, while another may want a lot of storage space. Yet another person may want a phone that doubles as a capable PMP. It's good to know exactly what you want when shopping for a cellphone, lest the sheer volume of choices available overwhelm you.

If you are one of those people looking for an ultra high-end smartphone then a simple list of features just isn't going to cut it. We've always agreed that for such cellphones one needs to consider the usability, intuitiveness and feel of the device in addition to the feature list and performance. Looks are also important for most people and even more so for someone spending a lot; he simply expects more.

Form Factors

Admittedly, some candy-bar phones look good; but the sheer commonness of this shape renders it less desirable. Amongst the ladies clamshells are hot. These cellphones open and fold just like their namesake and owing to the sleekness of the phone they're naturally considered as a female accessory.

This isn't necessary however, but a general consensus. The other hot form factor is the slider. Sliders are slick; and nothing grabs attention more than a resounding *click* as someone opens his slider phone to receive a call or send a message.

Initially we had reservations about extra moving parts on a cellphone since this usually results in mechanical failure over extended use. However, we've seen improvements made across the board by all major brands to prevent this; mechanically stressed parts are built better or reinforced.



Slider

Although mechanical parts are prone to greater wear sliders are undeniably hot. They have immeasurable flaunt value; just try sliding one open in public



Clamshell

If sliders are hot; clamshells are chic and fashionably cool



Candy bar

By far the most common form factor and for good reason. Can be attractive or dull looking; depends on the phone

Camera

This is one (admittedly over hyped) feature that probably sells more cellphones than anything else. Convergence is the name of the game here and everybody wants a camera to tinker around with on their cellphones. Obviously nearly every multimedia cellphone has a camera and while the best of these cameras will not be as good as a digital camera yet the convenience of having a cellphone that can be used to capture the odd photo cannot be dismissed. Usually cellphone cameras range from the mundane one megapixel and 1.3 megapixel peashooters to the high-end 5.0 and 8.0 megapixel cameras. Naturally the settings are what is most important since most cellphone cameras do not offer best results on automatic settings. You will need to check the cameras settings and menus before deciding on a model to buy.



Remember to take a look at the flash, as this is important especially when shooting in dimly lit areas. A dual LED flash is powerful, but not as powerful as a Xenon flash, which really lights up even dim shots; in fact we'd go as far as saying a cellphone camera without a flash unit is pretty much useless except for daylight, outdoor shooting.